

America, investment America, and mutual-fund America alike, the book's three principal targets.

But I fear, too, that this pathological mutation has spread more broadly across society, into the texture of so many of our lives. With Wikipedia at our fingertips and Google waiting online to serve us, we are surrounded by information, but increasingly cut off from knowledge. Facts (or, more often, factoids) are everywhere. But wisdom—the kind of wisdom that was rife in the age of this nation's Founding Fathers—is in short supply.

When I first expressed this skepticism about our Information Age more than a decade ago, I naively believed that it was an original thought. But there is nothing new under the sun, and I was delighted to learn recently that T. S. Eliot had expressed the same ideas—much more poetically, of course—in *The Rock* (1934):

*Where is the Life we have lost in living?
Where is the wisdom we have lost in knowledge?
Where is the knowledge we have lost in information?
The cycles of Heaven in twenty centuries
Bring us farther from God and nearer to the Dust.*

To paraphrase Neil Postman's essential message, soon we shall know everything that doesn't count, and nothing that does.

The Age of Reason

The Age of Reason that Postman applauded—what we now often describe as the Enlightenment—centered in the eighteenth century, and became central to western philosophy and society. The great intellectuals and philosophers who then populated western civilization didn't always agree with one another, but together they managed to implant in society a reliance on reason, a passion for social reform, and the belief that moral authority is integral to the successful functioning of education and religion as well as to commerce and finance.